

Mark Ratcliffe

MOVING & STORAGE

Overseas Moving Brochure

Your guide to international removals from Sussex

BAR Overseas Group Member · BS 8564 Accredited · APG Protected

Lower Dicker depot, East Sussex

markratcliffemoving.co.uk · 01323 848 008

Edition 2026

Welcome

Thank you for downloading the Mark Ratcliffe Moving overseas brochure. This document is the same one we hand to customers at our first survey meeting — a clear, no-jargon guide to how an international removal from Sussex actually works.

We are a family-run, independent removals company operating from our Lower Dicker depot on the A22, just outside Eastbourne. We have been shipping British households around the world since 2017. Our team is small enough that the surveyor who visits your home is usually the same person you speak to throughout the move, and the office is answered by name in working hours.

On the international side, we are a member of the British Association of Removers Overseas Group, independently audited each year to BS 8564 — the British Standard for international moving services — and every deposit you pay is protected under the BAR Advance Payment Guarantee.

WHAT THIS BROCHURE COVERS

- **How the process works** — from first call to delivery at your new address
- **The destinations we cover most often** — France, Spain, USA, Canada, Australia, New Zealand, UAE, South Africa, Thailand and beyond
- **Customs and ToR1 paperwork** explained in plain English
- **Realistic timelines** by destination
- **What to ship and what to leave** — practical guidance from years of moves
- **How pricing works** — fixed-price, no escalation clauses
- **Frequently asked questions**
- **How to get in touch** and book your free survey

How the process works

1. FREE SURVEY

Mark or a senior surveyor visits your home (in person across Sussex, Kent, Surrey and West Sussex; by video survey for outlying postcodes). We walk every room, identify items needing special handling, discuss customs paperwork, and confirm timing. Typical visit takes 45 to 60 minutes.

2. WRITTEN QUOTE WITHIN 48 HOURS

Fixed-price, itemised, valid for 30 days. Includes UK packing, road haulage to port, sea or air freight, destination customs entry and door-to-door delivery. No volumetric clauses that let us raise the price on the day.

3. BOOKING AND DEPOSIT

A 25% deposit secures your move date. Protected under the BAR Advance Payment Guarantee scheme. We issue a moving-day pack with crew lead contacts, customs paperwork to sign, and a checklist for self-packed items.

4. PRE-PACK AND PACKING

Packing materials delivered up to two weeks before move day. Optional full packing service or fragile-only packing. For international moves, we use export-grade pad-wrap and BAR-spec double-wall cartons throughout.

5. LOAD DAY AT YOUR HOME

Crew arrives 08:00–09:00 in uniform. Pad-wrap and load. Container or lorry sealed in your driveway with a numbered customs seal that only the destination agent can break.

6. UK CUSTOMS AND SHIPPING

Container or lorry transits to UK port (Felixstowe, Southampton, or Channel Tunnel for Europe). Customs clearance at Sevington (Kent) for EU, or at the port for sea freight. We send fortnightly position updates during sea voyages.

7. DESTINATION CUSTOMS AND DELIVERY

Our destination agent files customs entry against your ToR1 application. Once cleared, the agent's crew delivers to your new address, places furniture in agreed rooms and removes the pad-wrap. Optional box-by-box unpacking is available.

8. FOLLOW-UP

We call within a week of delivery to check everything arrived intact. Insurance claim, if any, filed within 14 days.

Destinations we cover

We move households to most countries — these are the destinations we handle most frequently from Sussex, each with our own dedicated process and vetted destination agent.

FRANCE

All regions. Channel Tunnel or Dover-Calais ferry. Typical 5–10 days door-to-door. ToR1 and French DAU customs entry handled.

SPAIN

Costa Blanca, Costa del Sol, Catalonia, Andaluc a, Balearics. Road via France or direct Bilbao/Santander ferry. NIE required. Typical 7–12 days.

ITALY & PORTUGAL

Northern Italy, Tuscany, the Algarve, Lisbon, Porto. ToR1 customs relief filed. Typical 8–14 days.

AUSTRALIA & NEW ZEALAND

Sydney, Melbourne, Perth, Brisbane, Auckland, Wellington. Sea-freight container shipping. AQIS / MPI biosecurity-compliant packing. Typical 8–14 weeks door-to-door.

USA & CANADA

NYC, LA, Boston, DC, Toronto, Vancouver, Montreal. ISF 10+2 filing, Form 3299 (US) or Form B4 (Canada) used-personal-effects relief. Typical 6–10 weeks.

UAE

Dubai, Abu Dhabi, Sharjah. Sea via Jebel Ali or air freight via Dubai International. Residency-visa-ready customs. Typical 4–6 weeks sea, 7–14 days air.

SOUTH AFRICA

Cape Town, Joburg, Durban, Port Elizabeth. Sea-freight via Felixstowe or Southampton. SARS P1.160 customs relief filed. Typical 8–12 weeks.

THAILAND

Bangkok, Pattaya, Phuket, Chiang Mai. Sea freight via Singapore transshipment. UK-Thai Movers Group member. Typical 8–12 weeks.

Customs paperwork

The single biggest cause of delays and unexpected costs on international moves is paperwork. We handle all of it as standard — what follows is background so you know what we are doing on your behalf.

TOR1 (TRANSFER OF RESIDENCE RELIEF)

ToR1 is the EU/UK customs scheme that allows people moving their main residence to import household goods without paying import VAT or duty. The four conditions: you are moving your normal place of residence; you have owned and used the items for at least 6 months; you will live in the destination country for at least 12 months; and the ToR1 application is filed in advance of the goods arriving (we file 14 days ahead as standard).

The cost of getting ToR1 wrong: typically 20–25% of the declared value of your goods in import VAT and duty — a multi-thousand-pound penalty for missing paperwork.

COUNTRY-SPECIFIC ENTRY DOCUMENTS

- France: DAU (Document Administratif Unique), filed via French destination agent
- Spain: DUA + your NIE foreigner ID number
- USA: ISF 10+2 filed 24 hours before vessel loading at the UK port (mandatory — \$5,000 per-violation penalty for non-filing). Form 3299 on arrival
- Canada: Form B4 (Personal Effects Accounting Document)
- Australia: AQIS biosecurity inspection — pre-cleaned outdoor items, ISPM-15 stamped wood packaging
- New Zealand: MPI biosecurity inspection (similarly strict)
- UAE: Residency visa with Emirates ID required for shipment release. Restricted items list applies (alcohol, pork, certain media)
- South Africa: SARS Form P1.160 personal-effects rebate. Residency permit required
- Thailand: Customs declaration via UK-Thai Movers Group agent in Bangkok

Realistic timelines by destination

Door-to-door times for a typical 3-bedroom household, sole-load (your own lorry or container). Part-loads add 2–7 days for European road freight and 2–4 weeks for sea-freight consolidation.

Route	Door-to-door	Notes
Europe (road)	5–14 days	France, Spain, Italy, Portugal, Germany, Netherlands
Sea freight — NYC area	6–8 weeks	New York, Baltimore, Boston, Philadelphia
Sea freight — US West	8–10 weeks	LA, San Francisco, Vancouver via Panama Canal
Sea freight — Australia	10–13 weeks	Sydney, Melbourne, Brisbane, Perth (Suez route)
Sea freight — NZ	11–14 weeks	Auckland, Wellington via Sydney transhipment
Sea freight — UAE	5–7 weeks	Jebel Ali (Dubai), Khalifa Port (Abu Dhabi)
Air freight — UAE	7–14 days	Dubai, Abu Dhabi (4–5× cost of sea)
Sea freight — South Africa	10–13 weeks	Cape Town, Durban, Port Elizabeth
Sea freight — Thailand	10–13 weeks	Bangkok via Singapore transhipment

WHAT ADDS TO THE TIMELINE

- **Part-load (groupage)** — 30–50% cheaper but adds days to weeks waiting for consolidation
- **Destination customs delays** — usually 5–14 days; rare to exceed 21 days with good paperwork
- **Biosecurity treatment** (Australia / NZ) — adds 7–21 days if any contaminated outdoor items
- **Visa / residency delays** at destination — we can hold in bonded warehouse for up to 30 days

What to ship — and what to leave

Not everything in your UK home is worth shipping overseas. We will tell you honestly at the survey what is worth the freight and what is cheaper to replace at destination.

Some general guidance:

USUALLY WORTH SHIPPING

- Quality furniture, particularly antique or sentimental pieces
- Art, framed pictures, mirrors (export-crated where appropriate)
- Books, vinyl, family records
- Personal china, glass and silverware
- Pianos (with our specialist piano-moving crews)
- Wine collections (where destination allows under ToR1)
- Clothes, linens, bedding
- Children's items, toys, hobby equipment

OFTEN NOT WORTH SHIPPING

- UK 13-amp electrical kitchen appliances (need adapters, may not meet destination safety standards)
- Fitted kitchens / wardrobes
- Mattresses (often cheaper to replace)
- Indoor and outdoor plants (biosecurity restrictions in most destinations)
- Food (prohibited in most countries; biosecurity in AU/NZ)
- Garden chemicals, paint, fuel
- Modern cars to USA/Australia (NHTSA/ADR compliance costs often exceed value)

ALWAYS RESTRICTED OR PROHIBITED

- Firearms (require destination-country import permit)
- Narcotics including some UK-legal prescription medications (UAE in particular)
- Alcohol in significant quantities (varies by destination)
- Pornography and content critical of destination government (UAE, China)
- Untreated solid wood not ISPM-15 stamped (AU, NZ, USA, EU)
- Soil, plants, seeds, food residues (AU, NZ — strictest)

How pricing works

Every overseas quote is fixed-price after our free survey. The figure we send is the figure you pay — no volumetric clauses that let us raise the price on the day, no surprise fees at destination.

WHAT IS INCLUDED AS STANDARD

- UK survey, planning and customs paperwork (including ToR1)
- Export-grade packing materials (cartons, paper, bubble wrap, pad-wrap)
- UK packing crew on load day
- Road haulage to port
- Container or lorry hire
- Sea or road freight to destination
- Destination port handling and customs clearance
- Destination agent's crew for delivery to your new address
- Furniture placement in agreed rooms and pad-wrap removal
- Marine transit insurance options (separately priced)

TYPICAL PRICE RANGES (2026)

- Europe road, 3-bed: £3,500–£7,500 (varies by destination region)
- USA / Canada, 20-foot container: £5,800–£8,800
- USA / Canada, 40-foot container: £8,000–£13,000
- Australia / NZ, 20-foot container: £6,500–£9,500
- Australia / NZ, 40-foot container: £8,500–£13,500
- UAE, 20-foot container: £5,500–£8,000
- South Africa, 20-foot container: £5,200–£7,800
- Thailand, 20-foot container: £5,500–£8,200
- LCL shared sea freight: typically £170–£260 per cubic metre
- Air freight: starts around £4,500 for 3 cubic metres

Frequently asked questions

HOW FAR IN ADVANCE SHOULD I BOOK?

For Europe, 4–6 weeks is comfortable. For sea-freight destinations (Australia, USA, UAE, South Africa, Thailand), 8–12 weeks is recommended so we can book your container into the sailing schedule that fits your dates.

DO I NEED TO BE THERE ON PACKING DAY?

Yes for the initial walkthrough so the crew can confirm which items go where. After that, many customers leave and return for the lockup. Door keys can be handed over to a neighbour or letting agent if you have already travelled.

CAN MY CAR GO IN THE CONTAINER WITH MY HOUSEHOLD?

Sometimes — depends on destination rules and container space. In practice, we usually recommend a specialist vehicle-shipper for cars to avoid mixing the import regulations. We coordinate so vehicle and household arrive within a few days of each other.

IS MY DEPOSIT SAFE IF YOUR COMPANY HAS A PROBLEM?

Yes. All deposits paid to us are protected under the BAR Advance Payment Guarantee scheme. If we were unable to perform the move, the APG underwriters refund your deposit in full.

WHAT INSURANCE IS INCLUDED?

Standard transit insurance is included against major loss events. Comprehensive marine transit insurance (covering individual item damage at the declared value) is strongly recommended for international moves and is arranged through a specialist Lloyd's broker. Premiums typically run 2–3% of declared value.

WHAT IF MY COMPLETION DATE SLIPS AT THE DESTINATION?

Common, especially overseas. We can hold goods in bonded warehouse at the destination port (typically £150–£300 per week) or arrange long-term storage in country. For UK-side slips, we store at our Lower Dicker depot in individual steel strong rooms.

WILL YOU HANDLE THE CUSTOMS PAPERWORK?

Yes — that is included as standard. We file the ToR1 application 14 days before shipment, prepare the inventory and valued list, and our destination agent files the country-specific entry document.

CAN I SEND WINE TO MY NEW HOME?

Yes in most European destinations under ToR1 (declared on inventory). Australia, NZ and the UAE have specific permits required and are sometimes not worth the cost. We will tell you at the survey what is realistic for your destination.

Get in touch

Ready to plan your overseas move? Here is how to reach us.

CALL US

01323 848 008

Office hours Mon–Fri 08:00–17:30, Sat 09:00–13:00

EMAIL

office@markratcliffemoving.co.uk

Reply within 1 working day

VISIT

Unit J12 Swallow Business Park

Diamond Drive, Lower Dicker, BN27 4EL

ONLINE

markratcliffemoving.co.uk

Free instant estimate + online quote form

Book your free overseas survey today

No obligation. Quote within 48 hours. Fixed-price.

Call 01323 848 008 · or visit markratcliffemoving.co.uk

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EMV London Ltd t/a Mark Ratcliffe Moving & Storage

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